

I have recently been thinking a lot about the frameworks people use to evaluate their lives. One that I find interesting is Dan McAdams' "actor-agent-author" model of identity, which decomposes who we are into 3 components:

(1) The actor speaks to what we are like - traits, temperaments, habits, and social roles. This could be things like "I am introverted." It's a sort of dispositional profile of yourself that you update over time.

(2) The agent tackles the question of "what am I trying to do?" It's a more active element of our identity. Many of our decisions are in pursuit of some goal ("I want to be successful") and work through our dispositions ("my idea of success is...")

(3) The author is the one I find most interesting, and it is concerned with the stories that we are living. It sees things not as simply emblematic of who we are, or stepping stones to broader goals, but rather as chapters in a continuously unfolding story. This concept of an internal life story is also called narrative identity.

My thoughts on this are as follows:

The way that I feel on a day-to-day basis has far less to do with individual moments, and is based more on the general "period" of my life that I'm in. During some periods of my life, I've been generally happy, and it's difficult for negative events or thoughts to silence that. Conversely, I've been generally sad, and even really great, electric moments have felt dull in the grand scheme of my life. The shift between these has something to do with what's actually happening - Are things going well? Do I have a healthy social network? Am I feeling stressed?

But I think alongside this, there is a very real effect that comes purely from the reframing of what I am “doing.” There are moments where I’ll tell myself something like “things are going to change now.” And I’ll sit there with my thoughts for a moment, and shore up a pool of courage, and resilience, and motivation. And with this, I’ll try to move towards that goal.

I think part of why this works for me is precisely because I’m constructing a cohesive story. Narratives change - that’s like, the whole thing. But they don’t often do so in sporadic and disconnected ways, there’s usually some central, overarching story (like a hero’s journey) that guides it from being one way to being another. Getting a bit better feels less fulfilling when it’s not a part of a broader process of *getting better*. The mind has a way of subconsciously sorting things, and running in the background in ways that may or may not be beneficial.

I think this has been a good piece of introspection for me - that even if not consciously, I am in part narrative driven. That makes me think of the phrase “do it for the plot,” which until now I had only thought of as a lighthearted way to suggest something.

When doing something, being able to fit it cohesively into a life narrative *makes* it feel more fulfilling. I thought of this when driving home in my car, which I just got today. I thought back on some of my previous “first drives,” the time I got my license and drove home for the first time, thrilled beyond belief. The time I drove my amazon rental car from Seattle Tacoma to my apartment and blasted The Saltwater Room while driving down the highway. Even then I thought “wow, how memorable.” I thought of this supercut of memories playing out, eventually unfolding neatly into the current moment - this drive was not *just* a drive, it was one of many novel experiences I would have in my life, which build from others, and will be looked back on fondly in the future.

That made it better. Thinking of life cohesively makes it feel better. That's not something I've ever explicitly thought about until recently, and it explains why it's so hard for crazy things to really feel bad. When you do something kind of insane, it fits neatly - it doesn't run against the grain or push back on your internal narrative in the way that losing a game in your winning era does. It's different, very different. That's why it's insane.

And the fact that it's different, at least for me, seems to open up almost a new chapter, or subsection. When I think back on my life, it's perforated by these moments - times when I decided to just throw my heuristics to the wind and do something novel.

Novelty is memorable, and memories are what builds the basis of my story, which is what provides meaning to the things I do, or at least it's a part of it. That seems more important than how good or bad it is. I have always understood this in some way, at least internally, so it's nice to have found this more standardized idea/framework to conceptualize it.